

AN ANGEL IN THE WHITE HOUSE

Mama came home saying it was just too good to be true—there was an angel in the White House, the new President's wife.

I had seen her, of course, in the Inaugural Parade, when the Democrats celebrated the return of their party to power and really whooped it up. The line was long, and the watchers jubilant. Mama was a little worried, because the President looked so stern with his long, lean face, so different from the Santa Claus features of Taft. Why, this man did not even have a mustache to soften his features!

I could hardly wait to hear what kind of people these were. It didn't take long to find out.

"Lillian," Mama said, "I hardly can believe my ears. I think we have an angel in the White House. She is talking about helping the poor and improving the housing." I had to admit that much as we were proud of our house, it could use some improvement; we had gas lights, and not even a furnace—we hovered around a small coal stove.

The next night, she told me, "Lillian, would you be-

lieve it, today the First Lady asked me all about you and Emmett, and she wants to come to see you."

I remembered how I'd felt when I saw Mrs. Wilson go by in the Inaugural Parade, in a big hat and elegant dress. Her hair was dark brown, and her eyes were soft and luminous. I had held my breath a moment because it seemed, for an instant, that she was looking straight at me.

Mama told me she had seen the President wandering around the hall with a Bible under his arm. He was, from all that Mama could gather, a very religious man, but one who did not make a show of it. He was the son of a minister, and Mrs. Wilson was the daughter and granddaughter of ministers.

When Mrs. Wilson's maid was away, Maggie would serve her, and she always came home shaking her head in amazement because a woman of such importance and such high rank could be so gentle. It was as if Mrs. Wilson wanted to make the world around her a little better place to live in.

One night, Mama came home with a box full of clothes, to be cut down for me. They were clothes from the Wilsons' girls, Margaret, Jessie, and Eleanor, reading from oldest to youngest. Our house was always clean, but for the impending visit of the First Lady, we polished and polished everything in sight. The White House, I'm sure, could never have been cleaner, even before any official reception.

Mrs. Wilson did come to visit quite unexpectedly, just as if it were the most usual thing in the world, and Mama showed her with simple pride the pieces of furniture she was buying one by one. Mrs. Wilson expressed admiration, and even made a few suggestions as to what would "look nice in that corner." Then, in the flicker of an eyelid, she was gone.

Mama explained that Mrs. Wilson was not only visiting

our place, but hundreds of places all over the Capital, to see how the poor people lived, and that she was going to do something to improve their slum conditions. Mama said that Congress was not pleased that a First Lady was getting involved in things that were men's business— and more openly than Mrs. Taft too. Mrs. Wilson was calling for legislation to clean up the slums of the Capital, and Congress was appointing a committee to look into her investigation to see what should be done.

Meanwhile, life at the White House was idyllic for Mama, and even the President had taken a kindly interest in her. Mrs. Wilson had told the President that Maggie was raising a crippled daughter. One day, the President saw Mama washing down the grand stairway. He said to an usher, "I don't ever want to see Maggie on her knees again." Thus Mama was relieved of one of her hardest jobs.

A strangely gentle way of life set the tone at the White House, so in contrast to life there with the Tafts.

Mrs. Wilson planted box bushes, rose bushes, and rose trees, making a garden between the White House and the President's office on the South Lawn. At one end of the garden was a marble bench with an awning over it. Here she had a telephone installed for the President, so he could keep her company while still remaining in touch with the Government.

A statue of a little boy overlooked the garden. Mama said that perhaps he was the little boy Mrs. Wilson wished she could have given the President to carry on his name. The President was very tender with his wife, and very attentive in the Rose Garden.

The servants considered Mrs. Wilson a beautiful woman, and they especially liked her soft voice, a contrast to Mrs. Taft's more authoritarian tones. She had hair and eyes that matched her voice in softness.

Backstairs, they called the President and his wife "the Professor and His Lady." If someone said, "The Lady wants her tray," that meant, in the mind of the person spoken to, "the Great and Good Lady," and I don't think a single servant disliked her. She laughed off mistakes, and always gave someone another chance.

But the Wilson girls were another matter— Margaret, Jessie, and Eleanor. It wasn't that they were disliked; it was just that they were full of girlish pranks and surprises, and no one knew what trick would be played on them next. They liked to confuse the servants by pretending they had asked for something they hadn't, or by popping out from dark corners to frighten them into dropping things. Their favorite trick was to pretend to be tourists and march through the White House with the other tourists, making nasty remarks about themselves.

Once, they did the same thing in the sight-seeing bus, and they came back howling with laughter, because they had gotten the driver to promise he would do everything in his power to get them in to see the whole White House.

Why they were not recognized I do not know, except that they were not beautiful girls, or the kind who especially draw attention. Mama said they really looked better than the newspaper pictures I saw of them. Eventually, I sewed for the youngest one when she was the wife of the Secretary of the Treasury (this was before I ever went to the White House to work), and found her very charming.

As Mama described it, the White House had become a household of women, all hovering around one man— a wife, three daughters, and even an extra woman, Miss Helen Bones, the President's cousin, who came to visit and stayed on, and on, and on. She became a sort of social secretary to the First Lady.

Mama heard the ladies laughing over the possibility that Mrs. Wilson might not have been in the White House if

only she had made the right bus connection. Mrs. Wilson was telling Miss Bones how she was trying to escape Woodrow Wilson when he was busy studying political history and teaching, and at the same time courting her. She was a young artist, intent on fame and fortune. He had written that he was coming to marry her, and she had run away. But she had missed her bus connection, and by some quirk of fate, Wilson's bus had pulled in right behind hers.

"I just gave up and married him," she said to Miss Bones with a laugh.

"But you shouldn't have given up your painting," said Miss Bones.

"Well, three daughters take more time than three canvases," said Mrs. Wilson, although she promised that she would get back to painting since the strain of the long years of hard work were over.

She did too. Mama helped her fix up a studio for an artist's workshop, and Mrs. Wilson spent many happy hours there. The pictures that she painted—landscapes—brought a good price because of her high position, and she sold them for every worthy cause—the education of Southern mountaineers and the crippled children of Washington, for example.

Years later, when President Eisenhower was painting, and I would see him at his easel, I wanted desperately to tell him what Mrs. Wilson had done, and to suggest that he too consider selling his paintings for some worthy cause, but I didn't feel that it was my place to do so.

The studio that Mrs. Wilson had fixed was up on the third floor, which was actually the attic of the White House. New stairs had to be put in to replace the attic-like steps. At the same time that the third floor was being done over, Mrs. Wilson added three more guest rooms, and a room I would frequently use in the future—a sewing room.

The Swedish cook, who had worked for Mrs. Taft,

stayed, though it meant a demotion under Mrs. Wilson. She had her own cook, whom she had brought from New Jersey, who ruled the kitchen. What Archie Butt had been to Taft, Col. Edward House was to President Wilson—advisor and constant guest at the White House.

Everyone asked Mama what manner of man Wilson really was—didn't he have any peculiarities? One of his peculiarities had to do with the lights. Mama was still the one who turned on the electricity in the private quarters of the White House every night, and under the Tafts, she was used to turning them on whenever she pleased. But President Wilson made a fetish of not being wasteful, and one night, as she was going around turning on lights, she found that he was right behind her, turning them off.

"Waste not, want not," he said, and after that, Mama made sure it was dark outside before she turned on any electricity.

But the strangest thing about the President was that he was really a frustrated actor. Mama would find him making faces, clowning, and doing a jig with his daughters, or taking a very serious part in a play, and speaking with one arm raised dramatically, as if he were on the stage.

He had a good audience, because all five women of the household adored him. So did the two dogs—Sandy, an Airedale, and Hamish, the English sheep dog, who had come with Miss Bones, and had taken up residence at the White House on a more or less permanent basis too.

His family could always get the President to go to a play, and no matter how tired he was, he was never too tired for the theatre. Once in a while, though, he would reach the saturation point of feminine company, and escape and play a game of solitaire. If the women wanted him then, he would tell Mama to tell them he was busy and would see them later. He would also escape to the golf

course, and he was called the second golfing President. Mr. Taft was the first.

Mrs. Jaffray was still in charge of the house, and in the servants' area, there was comment that sometimes she acted as if it were *her* White House alone, and then she would lord it over Mama and the other servants. But she proved she did have a heart when *Maggie* got sick with pneumonia after staying up very late at the White House, checking the wraps of the guests. She came to visit Mama, wearing her stately Queen Mary hat with veil, black kid gloves, and full regalia. Miss Helen Bones visited us too, and between them, they kept bringing every kind of food from calf's-foot jelly to spinach, in the hope that it would help *Maggie* get well fast.

And then suddenly things started to change at the White House. We didn't know it then, but it would never be the same. It began with the weddings of two daughters, *Jessie* and *Eleanor*. People did not know it, but Mrs. Wilson was already ill while she was in the thick of preparations for the wedding of her daughter *Jessie* to Francis B. Sayre.

Everyone in the kitchen held their breath to keep from disturbing the cake, which was being baked by the same woman who had made the wedding cake for Alice Roosevelt when she married Representative Nicholas Longworth. Her name was Mme. Blanche Rales, and she came from New York just to bake the cake in the White House kitchen. The cake stood thirty inches high, and was three feet across, and weighed 130 pounds. All the servants tiptoed by, afraid it would collapse.

Jessie's wedding took place in the East Room, November 25, 1913, at 4:30. I still have the invitation that Mama received. Mama and all the help shook their heads, because Miss *Jessie's* would be the thirteenth wedding in the White House. Someone mentioned it to her, but she only

laughed and said *she* felt lucky. She was too for twenty years, until her untimely death at the age of forty-five.

She was married standing on a white vicuña rug, a fur which had not yet come into disrepute in the White House and did not until the Sherman Adams vicuña coat incident. This rug was a gift of the Peruvian Ambassador, and was supposed to bring good luck to a bride.

Maybe the bad luck that *Jessie* did not have was passed with the wedding bouquet to Miss Margaret, because Margaret was not the next bride. Instead, *Eleanor*, the baby of the three, became the fourteenth bride of the White House. Everyone was more startled than thrilled when her engagement was announced to the Secretary of the Treasury, William Gibbs McAdoo, a widower who had grown children, some of them older than the bride-to-be.

The backstairs help talked of little else when the frivolous and light-hearted *Eleanor*, who was just in her early twenties, started seeing the middle-aged Secretary of the Treasury. "He's too old for her," some said. "She'll have trouble with his children," said others.

Mama didn't give her opinion at the White House, but when she got home, she ventured the theory that *Eleanor* was marrying in desperation, because she wanted to do everything her big sister did, and could not stand waiting. She could not believe that life was anything but a lark, because she had grown up in a happy atmosphere, with contented parents who showed deep love for each other. Weren't all marriages like that?

Some said that Mr. McAdoo was using her position to improve his own, because he had his eye on the White House too. One of the servants reported how shocked the President had looked the first night when the usher announced that the Secretary of the Treasury had come to see "Miss *Eleanor*." Typical of her, as the romance progressed, *Eleanor* was heard teasing the Secretary; she said

that she would not have anything to do with him unless he learned the new dance steps, and the Secretary, entering into the spirit of her challenge, permitted her to teach him to the music of the Gramophone.

The best story about the wedding ceremony was that Ike Hoover, chief White House usher, saved the day and the bride's dignity by rushing out and turning the bride's train when it looked as though she would get tangled and fall down in it.

She too stood on the vicuña rug to be married, but the luck of the rug did not hold out; eventually, she was divorced, and she never remarried.

In the beginning of the marriage, everything seemed sublimely happy. She had two children— Ellen, named for her mother, and Mary Faith. Margaret was now alone, and she had suitors by the score, but she was not interested in them. She was one of those newfangled career girls, and, like another famous White House daughter, Margaret Truman, she began a singing career while still in the White House.

It was as if Mrs. Wilson knew she had finished her work on earth, and could rest at last. She was very tired. She had seen two daughters happily married. Maybe she knew that the third daughter was too independent ever to marry.

But even in the last moments of life, her thoughts were with others. The President was with her when she died on August 6, 1914, and he came out of the room saying that her last words had been for the slum-dwellers of Washington, asking that something be done for them.

Until her body was taken to her home in Rome, Georgia, for burial, the family spent all their time in the hall outside her door. Sometimes they read; sometimes they just sat, so that they could be near her throughout the last possible moments.

Once, Mama heard the President talking to his dead

wife as he stood beside her body. She happened to be in the room at twilight when the President came in and stood looking at his wife's face. He picked at the lace on her dress, and Mama could hardly keep from crying at this wistful, hopeless scene. The President spoke aloud, brokenly, "Never, never, never." Then he walked out.

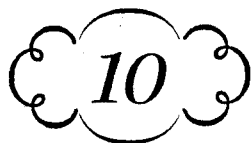
We tried to decide what he had meant as we sat in the kitchen of our little house, talking about the sad event at the White House, and shedding a few tears ourselves. Mama thought that maybe he meant he would never remarry.

If that were the meaning, even a President can change his mind, because life did go on, and new lives were born in the White House, and the President did remarry— perhaps even too soon. But don't let me get ahead of the story . . .

There came a day when the thought of Mrs. Wilson, though unspoken, was in the minds of everyone. That was the day when a new life came to the White House. Miss Jessie had come back to her White House home with her husband, to spend the first Christmas since the death of her mother, and here her first baby was born, Francis B. Sayre, Jr. Mama was called to the Small Rose Room, where the birth was taking place, and several nurses were standing by. Dr. Cary Grayson handed the baby to Maggie and said, "Take him to the fireplace in the Large Rose Room, and keep him warm."

Mama was walking out with the baby when the President arrived. He looked at the baby and then away, as if into the past, and tears filled his eyes. He didn't say anything.

It was the moment he could not share.



WHEN LOVE COMES TO THE WHITE HOUSE

The White House was in an uproar. The servants were upset. Some of the more dignified and conservative ones were saying it was too soon, it was almost indecent for a man to be courting a woman before his wife had been dead for a year.

It had happened so suddenly, so naturally, so innocently. The doctor who had taken care of Mrs. Wilson during her illness, Dr. Grayson, was in love with a Miss Gertrude Gordon, and the mood must have been contagious. Suffice it to say that an aura of love and romance hung over the White House, though at first, Dr. Grayson was the sole beneficiary.

Then, one day, Dr. Grayson came to tea with Gertrude and a lovely stranger. She was a widow, looked somewhat like the first Mrs. Wilson, and was dressed with quiet elegance. The servants noticed that the President did not send her home with Dr. Grayson, but took her home himself.

That was a day in March, 1915, just seven months after

he had become a widower. Still the staff wasn't too disturbed until they saw Mrs. Edith Galt arrive at the White House for lunch again and again.

Suddenly the President was effervescent and full of jokes. The happier he became, the sadder the servants were.

"He couldn't," said some.

"Wait and see," others predicted.

"She's a dozen years younger than his wife was," most everyone noted.

Almost everyone agreed that Dr. Grayson must have had something in mind, when he brought her over, beside his avowed purpose of finding someone to be a companion to his fiancée. Who was this woman? Mama explained that she was the widow of a man who had owned a jewelry store downtown— and that she wasn't poor.

As I waited each night for the next exciting chapter in the great romance of the century, I determined that as soon as possible, I too would work in the White House, because nowhere was life more exciting or the surroundings more beautiful.

I was growing up, and already in my teens. I was doing the cooking and cleaning, but I was still on crutches. Clearly, I would not be dancing in the near future. But even a cat may look at a queen, as Mama always said, and even I could dream of high romance. If I couldn't have it for myself, I assured myself, as a sort of promise, that I would put myself in a place where I could take part in other peoples' lives, and life would be as exciting as though it were happening to me.

"The Professor is writing love notes," Mama reported to my eager ears. "And I hear that he has sent over to the library to get all kinds of quotations about love so that he will know what Anthony said to Cleopatra and people like that."

"Have you seen any of the letters?" I asked.

"Heavens no, child, do you think I'm a snooper?" she said indignantly.

Frankly, I was disappointed. I wished heartily she had been a snooper, and I would have given my last penny to have taken a peek at the love letters that matched those of history and told what Anthony said to Cleopatra.

Evidently, the recipient of those letters was concerned, because a lot of other people were interested in them too; and years later, I heard that she had destroyed them all.

Mama reported that there was a rumor that Congress was angry because the President was spending too much time writing love letters when he should have been writing reports on the grave war situation in Europe. The question, said one angry Congressman, was not whether Mrs. Edith Galt loved Mr. Woodrow Wilson, but whether we were going to get into a war or weren't going to get into a war.

For a brief moment, Miss Margaret Wilson was able to grab the spotlight for herself by giving her first big concert. It was at Syracuse, and a record crowd of over six thousand people came to see the daughter of a President sing. For this she got \$1,000.

I waited to see what she would do with that money. New clothes? A trip around the world? No, she was a chip off the old block. She gave the money she had earned to two institutions for the blind in Washington. Mama's eyes were filled with tears when she told us this.

"She has the goodness of her mother," said Mama, "and it makes me feel that Mrs. Wilson is not really dead." Mama was in one of her philosophic moods. "That is the real reason for having children," she said, "and why I am glad I have you two. As long as I have you, I will always live."

I got her back to the subject of Edith Galt as soon as possible, because I was not in the mood for lectures. Mat-

ters of life and death seem very far away when you are young.

Mother told me she was going to go on the Presidential yacht, the *Mayflower*, with the President and Mrs. Galt for a short cruise, and that they would see a big naval parade.

"Are you going all alone with them?" I asked.

"Of course not," Mama assured me. "There will be many chaperones— Miss Margaret, Miss Bones, Dr. Grayson, Miss Gordon, the President's secretary, and several others." Mama's job was to take care of all the ladies, especially if they should get seasick, and to help them dress and fix their hair.

They started for New York, but soon ran into a big storm on Chesapeake Bay. Everyone except President Wilson and one sailor got sick. Mama couldn't help any of the ladies, because she was the sickest of them all.

After they had reached New York, and the ground steadied under foot, Mama had a magnificent time as part of the Presidential party. But the curious crowd pushed them so, that she was frequently in danger of being lost from the group. Miss Bones, who took charge of Mama, said to her, "Hold on to me, Maggie, and I'll get you through."

The engagement of the President and Mrs. Galt was announced on October 7, 1915, but by this time the White House crowd had adjusted to the idea of a new First Lady. The wedding was set for December 18, and officials had a "let's-get-it-over-with-and-back-to-work" attitude.

One person who didn't approve of the marriage was Colonel House, who had come down from New York to warn the President that if he were to marry so soon, he would lose the election the following year. This just made the President, who was a real fighter, determined to get married right away.

The Colonel was the only person from whom the Presi-

dent would take advice, but Mama said that in this case he had used the wrong tactic. Wilson wasn't the kind of man to let public opinion scare him.

I waited eagerly each night to hear what new presents had arrived for the bride-to-be. There were crates of candy— Mama brought me home a sample— a great number of cakes, which were slowly getting stale, enough soap and toilet preparations to keep an elephant spanking-sweet for a lifetime, and, oddly enough, one barrel of popcorn. That was my favorite gift. Mama, being furniture-conscious, was more interested in the gorgeous rugs, table linens, clocks, silverware, delicate glass, and even a sixteenth century Chinese Ming bowl. I still treasure the invitation that she received to the wedding.

Little did we know when the happy couple made their vows in Mrs. Galt's tiny living room off Dupont Circle, and went to Hot Springs, Virginia, for two weeks' vacation, that this would be a most unusual marriage.

At first, it was everything a marriage should be— a wedding out of a story book. The President and Mrs. Wilson had breakfast together in the family dining room, and the bride walked to the office with her husband through the Rose Garden. If the new Mrs. Wilson knew that the roses had been planted by another Mrs. Wilson, she did not let on. But sometimes, when Mama saw the President stop and stoop to smell a rose, she would wonder, and the servants sometimes commented that they wished the new Mrs. Wilson would use a different route.

The first social season under Edith Galt Wilson was a brilliant one, starting off with a diplomatic reception in January, 1916. Mrs. Wilson stood tall and beautiful in a white gown, brocaded with silver, and draped with white tulle. Then came a ball at the new Pan American Union, which Mama always claimed was the most elaborate affair she had ever seen. Mrs. Wilson stood out from all the

dazzling colors by wearing a black velvet gown and carrying a grey feathered fan. Mama was sent over to the Pan American Union simply to check Mrs. Wilson's evening wrap when she arrived.

The new Mrs. Wilson was certainly different from the first Mrs. Wilson, who had not even held an Inaugural Ball when she first came to the White House.

It was a gay life at the White House, but Mrs. Wilson danced on the brink of war. On May 24, 1916, there were more festivities when Dr. Grayson married his fiancée in New York, and the President and his bride attended.

But by the next month, war clouds hovered over our shores, and there was talk of little else. President Wilson led a preparedness parade from the Peace Monument, at the foot of the Capitol grounds, to the White House. And then he started making trips around the country, delivering campaign speeches in which he talked of preparedness.

The President wanted another term in office. In the kitchen and sewing room, and in the halls of the White House, the servants wondered whether the marriage of the President so soon after he had been widowed would lose him the election. That there was another issue— turned into the slogan "He kept us out of war"— did not seem as important to us as his personal life, probably because he had given himself over so completely to his romance.

Election day came and went, and it looked as if he had lost. At home, we all went to bed on election night with the report that Charles Evans Hughes had been elected. Mama felt terribly sorry for Mrs. Wilson, who might have been blaming herself. She also felt pretty sorry for herself, because she had been assigned to help Margaret, and liked that position very much.

When Margaret asked for her, Mama was a little afraid to accept, because that would mean that if Wilson had lost the election, she, as the personal maid to the family, would

be out of a job too. But Wilson had told Mama not to worry, that she would always have a job.

After several days of great anxiety, it became apparent that Wilson had won after all, and Mama still had a job at the White House. We were as happy as the President.

Since March 4 was a Sunday, for the fifth time in history the inauguration ceremony was on a Monday, and, as a spectator, I saw that the second Mrs. Wilson looked positively radiant in a Lillian Russell hat and black velvet suit, highlighted with violets. Violets seem to have been a tradition for inaugurations, for Mrs. Taft had worn them at the first inauguration I ever saw. Soon, the second Mrs. Wilson switched to orchids, and they became a fad and then a fashion for those who could afford them. The fashion is still with us today.

The second Mrs. Wilson liked to show friends the Lincoln bed, which she had installed in her suite rather than the President's. When she used it, it still had the original canopy, which was removed by the time I went to work at the White House. I once saw the original record of the purchase of the bed. It cost \$375.50, including the "canopy and curtains." It was dated December 21, 1864, and was approved January 3, 1865, by "Mary Lincoln." The dimensions of what is probably the world's most famous bed are as follows: length, 8 feet; width, 51½ feet; headboard, 9 feet tall.

I was queen for a night when Mama smuggled me into the White House to see how a State dinner takes place. I watched from behind potted palms as the guests arrived in their furs and finery, and later, she changed my position, so I could see how President Wilson and the First Lady marched in to dinner with their guests.

Margaret Wilson had her own piano in her room and practiced religiously, making big plans for her career. We wished she were prettier, so that her chances of success

would be increased; we hoped she would realize a career on her own, without the glamor of her father's name.

"The trouble with Margaret," the staff downstairs agreed, "is that she's the spitting image of her father." There was nothing sweet and girlish about *his* looks. Margaret knew that folks came to see "the daughter of the President" rather than the independent young lady with plans of her own. In talking her father into letting her appear in public, she pointed to the precedent set by President McKinley's niece, who started her career with White House backing also. Though Mabel McKinley was crippled, she had sung in vaudeville.

As I sat at home, listening to the story of how President McKinley's niece had used crutches to walk on the stage, because she had been crushed by some falling lumber when she was a child, it gave me new hope for my own future. I looked at my own crutches leaning against the wall, and vowed again that somehow I would be a part of the White House life. There must be some way I could go to work there, crutches or no crutches.

Though Margaret Wilson frequently sang at the White House, Mama said that the guests did not consider this a treat; it was simply the price of being invited. Mama wished she could design a new hairdo for her, but didn't feel that it was "her place" to tell a President's daughter what to do.

McKinley's niece, Mabel, had sung at the White House too, but it was said that she had had a beautiful face. Mabel had even succeeded in catching a husband, in spite of her crutches— a doctor, Hermanus Baer— and McKinley had attended the ceremony.

But Margaret Wilson never did marry. Instead, her story has a sad ending. She went to India, to live in a religious Hindu colony in Pondicherry, and died of uremia. Before

she departed, to study the doctrines of Sri Aurobindo, she vowed never to return to the United States.

What part her father's remarriage played in her disillusionment, I have always wondered. But when she was at the White House, with Maggie looking after her, she felt deserted by everyone, what with two married sisters, and a father busy with a new bride. So she threw herself into music, in a search for beauty in her own life. She was as generous with Mama as her mother had been, and sent boxes of clothes and candies home to me with Mama.

A second grandchild was introduced to the White House. A baby girl had been born to Eleanor McAdoo, and soon tiny Ellen McAdoo was wheeling over to the White House in her pony cart, which was large enough to accommodate a nurse and a footman.

As Mama described it, her arrivals at the White House would be quite a sight. Everyone would ask her who lived at the White House, hoping to hear her say "Grandfather," but she would always answer "Mays."

The President laughed and laughed, because his grandchild always gave the doorman, John Mays, top billing. Mays would treat Miss Ellen with great dignity, and, after he had lifted her from her cart, she loved to stand and talk with him about all her adventures instead of rushing in to see the President.

This beautiful child had a tragic life. She grew up and married, but later she destroyed herself.

The President did not seem too happy after the election. It must have hurt him to know he was not popular enough to have won a clear victory— he barely squeaked through.

After the President had remarried, at first a few servants grumbled that they did not want to work for any Indian, regardless of her status. Mrs. Edith Wilson did not deny that she had some Indian blood; in fact, Mama heard her

tell a guest that she was a direct descendant from Pocahontas. She was a ninth generation descendant of the Indian Princess. Mama used to study her face to see how much of the Indian ancestry showed, and she decided that a certain firmness of line and straightness of feature could have come from the Indians. No one denied that the new Mrs. Wilson was beautiful, and her knowledge of her own beauty was visible also, which did not help her win friends, as the first Mrs. Wilson had done.

The new Mrs. Wilson had only one goal— to please her husband. She paid attention to very little else, but concentrated on being a complete companion. No outside hobbies did she have, no painting, no designing of gardens. She centered her full and complete attention on her husband, and even went golfing with him.

The poor President could not even turn to golf to get away from the womenfolk. Nor did he have time. He was busy with his war problems every moment.

Colonel House was at the White House much of the time, and the President leaned on him heavily— even working out a special code so they could send confidential messages to each other. Mama was pleased that Colonel House and the new Mrs. Wilson became friends, and Mrs. Wilson entered into the spirit of things. Mama would often see her busy at coding and decoding for the President.

His concentration was beginning to show on him, but so was her concentration on him beginning to tell on her. She became so exhausted, that several times, she went to bed for a full day to relax and at least partially unwind. Cabinet officers and advisors came to the White House at all hours of the day and night. The President's work hours started at dawn.

To top it all, as a minor irritation, lady suffragettes were starting to picket the White House. Strangely enough, the man who wanted a League of Nations was not equally

interested in rights for women. It was some time before he was convinced that women should vote.

Once, when the Russian delegation was visiting the White House, the suffragettes congregated outside in full force with a streamer that read, "We, the women of America, tell you that America is not a democracy. Twenty million American women are denied the right to vote. President Wilson is the chief opponent of their national enfranchisement. Help us make this nation a really free nation. Tell our government that it must liberate its people before it can claim free Russia as an ally."

I still have the clipping that shows the ladies picketing. But what it doesn't show is how Wilson looked, on the other side of the fence, as he peered out the North windows of the White House at the entrance where the ladies were marching. Mama said he was greatly upset. Someone went out and copied the exact words on the streamer, so that the President would know what the message said.

The President thought about it, then replied, "I don't care what they say, because they have a right to their opinion, but I still think we should invite the ladies in for some hot tea. It's cold out there."

Mrs. Wilson did not want them invited, for she was quite indignant about the whole thing, but the President told Ike Hoover to extend his invitation to the ladies to come and warm themselves in the White House.

Mr. Hoover returned alone. The ladies had refused the hospitality of the White House. Mama said that this seemed to hurt the President most of all. Eventually, several women were arrested for disturbing the peace and sentenced to *fifteen days* in jail. One of the servants spread the word among us that the President wanted to issue a pardon for the ladies, so that they would not have to serve jail sentences, and that the First Lady wanted them to

stay in jail so that it would serve as a lesson to them to act with more dignity in the future.

"She probably wants to have them burned at the stake," said one of the staff who was most prejudiced against Indians, and before we knew it, a new nickname had been added. The President and his First Lady were now "the Professor and Pocahontas."

War was declared on April 6, 1917, and the First Lady went with the President up to Capitol Hill when he made the war declaration. Later, the White House staff was shocked when, instead of speaking of all the misery that war would bring, Mrs. Wilson talked about how the galleries had applauded her husband. She just didn't seem to realize the meaning of war.

Mama found out what it meant, because she did not get any letters from Emmett, who was shipped to France with the First Expeditionary Force.

Emmett had gotten into the army the year before, without Mama's help. I remember that he had gone directly to the White House to see Mama in the summer of 1916; he wanted her to sign a note, giving him permission to enlist, because he was not yet eighteen. Mama refused.

When she came home that night, there was Emmett in full uniform. He was big for his age and had gotten in anyway. Mama looked at him and turned pale. Then she said, "Don't ask me to get you out, and never disgrace that uniform."

Emmett had gone to the Mexican border with the American Expeditionary Force, headed by General Pershing, to capture General Francisco "Pancho" Villa, a mission which was never accomplished. Emmett then was assigned to guard duty in the War Department. He was part of the special guard assigned to the missions that came to visit the United States—the British, the French, and the Bel-

gian. Mama was very proud of his position of trust and honor. He had not disgraced her.

During the war, Mama did not know where Emmett was, but gave a package to one of the White House military aides who said he would be seeing him. She waited, but heard nothing from him, and she feared that he had been killed.

There was no sleep for anyone in the White House during the war. The First Lady finally got interested in some activity other than being a companion to her husband; she worked with the Red Cross, rolling bandages and doing other menial tasks.

All the social functions were discontinued at the White House, and Mrs. Wilson inaugurated meatless days, heatless days, Sunday gasless days— meaning no Sunday pleasure drives— and she spent many hours before her own sewing machine making pajamas for the soldiers in the hospital wards, to be distributed by the Red Cross. Her secretary, Edith Benham, and Miss Bones, who was still at the White House, helped.

Conservation was the byword around the White House; eight sheep were soon to be seen gracing the lawns— for a while “Pocahontas” became “Little Bopeep” to the White House help. But her idea was finally applauded by even her worst critics among the staff, when many thousands of dollars were raised for the Red Cross through the auctioning of the wool. Two pounds of wool were sold for each state when the sheep were fleeced of almost a hundred pounds of raw wool.

Another successful money-raising idea of the First Lady's was to have famous movie stars sell liberty bonds on the Treasury steps. It was a great occasion, to my glamor-hungry mind, to see Mary Pickford, “America's Sweetheart,” Charlie Chaplin, “America's Clown,” the romantic

idol, Douglas Fairbanks, and the dignified Marie Dressler in the flesh.

When the President heard that Mama was worried about Emmett's safety, he shook her hand warmly and said that he hoped that her son would return. Emmett did return after the war, but it was the President himself who was the war casualty, for he suffered a series of strokes, one of them on his bathroom floor in the White House, after returning in a state of collapse from a speaking tour.

Of course, it was a delayed action breakdown that took almost a year to come about. Mama said that in one year he had won the war and lost the peace, and his health with it.

What happened is that immediately after the Armistice in 1918, the President, in an exhausted state, went to Paris twice in rapid succession to preside at the Peace Conference, and to set up a League of Nations. Mama was invited to go along to be Mrs. Wilson's personal maid in Paris. She didn't want to leave me, so the Swedish cook, who knew foreign languages, got to go.

I didn't want Mama to miss such a trip for my sake, but she insisted on making the sacrifice anyway. Had she gone, she would have had the thrill of seeing our President hailed as an idol, and streets and avenues named for him. She would have stayed at Buckingham Palace in London, and ridden in the royal train of King Victor Emmanuel in Italy.

As it was, she only got to hear the angry voices of Congress, led by bearded Senator Henry Cabot Lodge (whose name was not to be mentioned in the White House), make fun of “naïve” Wilson and his League. It was after he had returned from France again and made a twenty-five day speaking tour of the country, trying to convince the people of the need for a League of Nations, that he simply could go no further, and collapsed in Pueblo,

Colorado, after mumbling and crying his way through the last incoherent speech. That day of doom was September 26, 1919.

Suddenly the White House became a hospital. Hardly anyone knew what was going on except that the President had returned ill. By October 4, his collapse was almost total. He would never be able to use half his body again. Mrs. Wilson gave up her Red Cross work and lived the life of a nurse.

As the President hovered between life and death, no one dared tell him how grave his condition was, for fear he would lose his will to live. Even as he lay at death's door, word came that the Senate had rejected the Versailles Peace Treaty, because the League participation was part of it. Mrs. Wilson was in continual consultation with the doctor over whether or not the President should resign.

As the crisis passed, the word got around the White House that the First Lady could still not even suggest to the President that he resign, because if he could not work toward the eventual American acceptance of the League of Nations, he would quite possibly lose any hope or will to live. The League was his magnificent obsession, even in his sickbed ramblings.

From then on, the White House saw Mrs. Wilson become more and more involved in the actual workings of the Government. Documents were delivered directly to her, and she stayed up late nights studying. Cabinet officers and Congressmen came to see her. Mama said you could just see the First Lady mature and develop judgment as she became more and more involved in the affairs of the nation.

In the kitchens and back halls of the White House, the regulars were shaking their heads. They were glad that the President had weathered the storm and was improving, but

most of them thought he should resign and allow a competent man take over the reins of Government.

A houseman tried to be funny about it when he said, "I always knew it would happen. The Indians have finally taken over Washington, and now we'll all be scalped."

Mama did not think that was too funny. She was all for Mrs. Wilson and what she was doing. In fact, for the first time, Mama seemed to have the same love for the second Mrs. Wilson as she had had for the first. The second First Lady's example was, to Mama's mind, a sign of how capable women could be when given a chance, and she was proud of the way in which Mrs. Wilson had risen to the occasion.

"She will go down in history as a great woman," Mama predicted sagely, nodding her head as she told me how the President's wife was laboring to keep a Government in good working order. The word was that the President was able to think things through and make decisions, and that Mrs. Wilson carried out his orders, and helped him sign his name to the important papers.

But, as months and months rolled by, and the First Lady was still acting as the unofficial President, newspapers showed that the public was greatly disturbed. Once Mama was in the room when Mrs. Wilson, in a very low frame of mind, struggled with some papers. "I just don't know how much more criticism I can take," she said sadly, pointing at the newspapers beside her.

Mama told her then of the sign that Mrs. Taft had ordered printed and put on President Taft's desk. It was a quotation from Lincoln, which Mama had copied for herself, and she showed it to Mrs. Wilson:

"If I were to try to read, much less answer, all the attacks made on me, this shop might as well be closed for any other business. I do the very best I know how—the very best I can, and I mean to keep on doing so until the end. If the

end brings me out all right, what is said against me won't amount to anything. If the end brings me out wrong, ten angels swearing I was right would make no difference."

From then on, Mama prayed every day for strength for the First Lady so that she could carry on her work, and for the quick recovery of the President. When Miss Margaret went to New York to live and to continue her vocal studies, Mama chose to stay at the White House rather than accompany her. Mama really felt that Mrs. Wilson needed her and what little she could do to help her.

Various members of royalty came to visit the President while he was ill, including the Prince of Wales, who was later to lose his crown for love just as Wilson almost lost his Presidency in the re-election. What hurt Mrs. Wilson the most was that people were saying the President was insane, and that his guardians had found it necessary to put bars on his bedroom windows. Over and over, she explained that the bars were on the windows of another room, and had been installed long ago for the protection of Teddy Roosevelt's children.

Mrs. Wilson also protested that the President's mind was completely untouched by the paralyzing stroke he had suffered, but, of course, Mama was not able to confirm this. Mama did see that President Wilson was able to receive the King and Queen of Belgium, who brought with them a wonderful thousand-piece set of china, showing historic places in Belgium.

But to show how a little thing could keep things in an uproar, once they were going badly, when the Queen was interviewed downstairs on her way out of the White House, she mentioned that the President had been dressed in a warm wool sweater.

The reporters misunderstood, and the stories came out that the President was wearing a "torn" wool sweater. Indignant ladies from all over the country wrote to tell the

First Lady that they didn't approve of the poor care the ailing President was receiving. Mama didn't know whether to laugh or to cry.

The Congress eventually sent two Senators over to check on the condition of the President's mind, and they came out gasping that they wished their own minds were as sharp and clear. One of them had told the President that they were praying for him, and the President had retorted, "Yes? Which way?"

Mama was also convinced that his mind was clear, but she suffered agonies when he would try to give her a little smile as he was wheeled around the White House in his wheel chair, and the smile would come out twisted because he could use only half his face. For this reason, the Secret Service men would place him in his car, when he was being taken out for fresh air and sunshine, so that people would not see the frozen side.

That was really pathetic, because he was so crushed by the change from his triumphal European tour and the roaring, approving crowds, to his lonely life of invalidism, that the White House staff would go out and cheer him when he would return from his ride. Mama would come home and cry about that. The First Lady would cry a little too when he would say to her, "You see, I'm not too unpopular."

Mama would both laugh and cry about his childish irritability, which had resulted from the breakdown. She told me how he would pout if he didn't have his way; how he would set up rules for everyone; and how one time, when his wife hadn't consulted him about a drive, he refused to ride in a car and ordered a horse and carriage for himself instead.

Congress might think that the world was not ready for the League of Nations, but the White House staff was, and from the lowliest houseboy to the eloquently-dressed

ushers, the White House staff felt that Wilson could really have saved the world from future wars, and that he was the man who had the vision to understand what was needed. They had seen him with his Bible enough to know that he was a completely sincere and religious man, who asked the help of God in whatever he did.

When he went to France and attended the Peace Conference, they held their breath. Though it was superstitious, they felt it was bad luck for him to break the unwritten law that an American President does not leave American territorial waters. Wilson was the first President to set foot on foreign soil during his term of office, and his vision of America's joining the League of Nations went down the drain.

Just one funny thing happened on the trip abroad, and it happened to a White House maid. Mama said that maybe she should have gone just to have been there when it happened. When they were staying at Buckingham Palace, Queen Mary graciously asked this maid, when all the White House staff was lined up before her, "Are your quarters satisfactory?"

In spite of all the prior coaching she had received, the maid said with great enthusiasm, "They sure are, Queen! You bet!" She came back in disgrace, and was transferred out of the White House to another job.

When it was time for the Wilsons to leave, a year and a half after his stroke, the President gave Mama two oil paintings for the living room, which his first wife had told him about. Mama didn't have the heart to tell him we had finally had to give up the little house and move to an apartment, because the terribly long hours Mama had been spending at the White House had made it impossible to take care of our home. She also received a hundred-dollar Government savings bond. But, more than the money—which went to pay for new braces for my leg and fillings

for my teeth—Mama cherished the gift she got from Margaret, a record of her singing.

Of such things are dreams made—a record that brings back the voice of a girl who once laughed and sang in the White House, and then renounced her country; two wedding invitations, grown a little yellow; and a photograph of a beautiful woman, who married with high hopes and became a scapegoat for a disgruntled nation.

But the White House still looked pretty glamorous to me, and I could hardly wait to fit myself into it somewhere.

Mama helped Mrs. Wilson pack her things to move to a little house in Washington. Mama had a personal interest in reading about the conventions that were being held to see who would be chosen to take the place of Wilson.

When the Republicans had their convention, the papers told about the wife of one of the candidates; she was sitting in the gallery, watching and keeping an eye on everything. She was supposed to be manoeuvring behind the scenes with the party politicians to get the nomination for her husband, in case they couldn't decide on a front-runner. And she did.

That woman was Mrs. Florence Harding. Mrs. Wilson had said sadly to Mama, "If I had done that, think of what they would have said." But it hurt even more when Harding adopted as his slogan "Return to normalcy." Mrs. Wilson took that as a personal insult, as though she had not done her best to keep things normal.